

Interview Topic Guide:

Semi-structured, in-depth interviews with scheduled caste mukhiyas in Bihar

Estimated duration: 40-60 minutes

Introduction:

Namaste, my name is Amol Shaila Suresh, and I am a student at the London School of Economics in the United Kingdom. Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today. I really appreciate it.

A day or two ago, we sent you an audio note on WhatsApp explaining this research. If you have had a chance to listen to it, that is great. If not, or if you would like me to go over it again, that is completely fine. Let me briefly explain.

I am carrying out research to understand the experiences of Scheduled Caste mukhiyas in Bihar: what your day-to-day life in office looks like, the kinds of challenges you may face, and how you navigate your role as an elected leader. I am interested in learning from your experiences in your own words.

Before we begin, I want to share a few important things.

First, your participation is completely voluntary. You are free to refuse to answer any question, take a break whenever you need, or stop the interview at any point. You do not need to give me a reason, and there will be no consequences of any kind. There is no cash or in-kind compensation for participating.

Second, everything you share with me will be kept strictly confidential. I will not use your real name anywhere in my research. I will use a false name. I will also not mention your village, block, or district, or anything else that could identify you. Your name and identity will not be shared with anyone.

Third, we may discuss some sensitive topics today, including experiences of discrimination, difficult encounters, or possibly incidents of intimidation or violence. If at any point you feel uncomfortable, please tell me and we will pause or stop. If discussing these experiences causes you any distress, I have a list of helplines and organizations in Bihar that provide support, and I would be happy to share them with you.

Fourth, I would like to audio-record our conversation so I can listen carefully and not miss anything you say. The recording will be stored securely, only I will have access to it, and it will be used only for my dissertation and possibly future academic writing, always with your identity protected. Is it okay with you if I record our conversation?

[Wait for verbal confirmation. Begin recording.]

[After recording begins, confirm on record:]

Just to confirm on the recording: you have understood what this research is about, you are participating voluntarily, and you are giving your consent to be interviewed and recorded. Is that correct?

[Wait for verbal confirmation.]

Thank you. If you have any questions before we begin, please feel free to ask. Otherwise, shall we start?

Section 1: Personal and political background

- To begin, could you tell me a little about yourself – where you are from, your family, what do you do for living, and what your everyday life looks like? *(first, you answer these questions)*
- How did you first become involved in public life or politics in your village? Walk me through how that journey started. *Probes (only if not covered):*
 - Was there a particular moment, person, or event that pushed you toward politics?
 - Had anyone in your family or community been involved in political work before?
- Before you became mukhiya, how would you describe your everyday interactions with different people in the village – neighbors, upper-caste families, people in positions of influence? *Probes:*
 - What did a typical week of your life look like then?
 - Were there spaces or situations where you felt more comfortable, and others where you felt less so?

Section 2: Contesting the election

- Tell me about the time when you decided to contest the mukhiya election. How did that come about? *Probes:*
 - Who did you talk to about this decision?
 - What were the reactions of people around you when they heard?
- What was the experience of campaigning like for you? *Probes:*
 - What kinds of conversations did you have with voters from different communities?
 - Were there places you went where you felt welcomed, and places where you felt the opposite?
- During the election period, did anyone approach you with offers, suggestions, or pressures – of any kind – about your candidacy? *[Note: This is the proxy / bribery / withdrawal probe. Do not rush. Let silence do work. If participant gives a short answer, follow with:]*
 - Can you tell me more about that? What exactly did they say?
 - How did you respond?
 - Did anything change for you after that conversation?
- On election day itself, and in the days right after the result – what do you remember most clearly? *Probes:*
 - Was there anything that happened that surprised you, positively or negatively?
 - How did different people in the village react once the result was announced?

Section 3 – In office: Relationship with bureaucracy

- Once you took office, you must have started visiting the Block office, District office, and other government offices regularly. Can you walk me through what those visits have typically been like for you? *Probes:*
 - Is there a particular visit that stands out in your memory? What happened?
 - How are you usually received when you arrive?
- Think about a time when you went to an officer - the BDO, the Program Officer, the SDO, anyone – with a file or an application. How did that encounter unfold? *Probes:*
 - What happened with the file after you submitted it?
 - Did the officer meet with you right away, or did something else happen?

- Have you had similar experiences with other officers?
- Have you ever had the sense that your work as mukhiya was being delayed or blocked in ways that seemed unusual? Can you tell me about that? *Probes:*
 - Did you ever learn why it was happening?
 - What did you do about it?
- Have you had the chance to observe, or hear about, how other mukhiyas in your area are treated by the same officers? What have you noticed? *[Note: This is the comparative / differential treatment probe. Let the participant name the comparison – do not lead with caste.]*
- When these kinds of things happen at the Block or District office, what do you usually do next? What have you found works, and what has not worked?

Section 4 – In office: Relationship with upper-caste elites and villagers

- Thinking about social life in the village since you became mukhiya – weddings, ceremonies, funerals, festivals, chai shops, public gatherings – how have those experiences been for you? *Probes:*
 - Is there a specific occasion that comes to mind when you think about this?
 - Has anything happened at such a gathering that you remember clearly?
- How do people in the village address you and speak with you now, compared to before the election? *Probes:*
 - Is it different with different groups of people?
 - Have you noticed things people say behind your back, or things said directly to you?
- Since taking office, have you had any moments where you felt you were being treated differently because of who you are – your background, your identity, your community? *[Note: This is the core microaggression probe. Phrased openly so participant can name whichever dimension feels most significant. Do not specify caste – let them.] Probes:*
 - Can you describe one such moment in detail?
 - What was said or done? What did you feel at that moment?
 - How did you respond?
- Are there people in the village – from any community – who have supported you, stood with you, or helped you when things were difficult? *[Note: Important counterweight question. Avoids framing the mukhiya's life as entirely one of suffering, and surfaces resilience and social resources often missed in backlash-focused research.]*
- When difficult social situations happen – slurs, exclusion, confrontations – how do you typically handle them? Has that changed over your time in office?

Section 5 – In office: governance, authority and independent decision-making

- As mukhiya, you take many decisions every week – about schemes, development works, beneficiary selection, gram sabha meetings, and so on. Tell me about a decision you took that you feel proud of. *Probes:*
 - What made that decision important?
 - How did people react to it?
- Have there been decisions where others – inside or outside the panchayat – tried to influence what you would do? Can you tell me about one such instance? *Probes:*

- Who were these people, and what did they want?
- What did you end up doing?
- What happened afterward?
- Some mukhiyas operate quite independently, while others work more closely with advice or instructions from others in the village. How would you describe your own way of working? *[Note: This is the proxy / independence probe, phrased neutrally so participant does not feel judged either way. If they describe independent operation, follow up on consequences; if they describe more collaborative operation, follow up on who they collaborate with and why.]*
- Have you taken any steps during your tenure that you feel were particularly important for your community – for SC families, for marginalized groups, for people who had been excluded before?
Probes:
 - What pushed you to do this?
 - How was it received, and by whom?
- Are there symbols, figures, or ideas that are important to you and that you have tried to bring into your work as mukhiya – through the panchayat office, public events, or village spaces? *[Note: Open probe for Ambedkar / rights-assertion themes. Let the participant name these themselves rather than asking directly.] Probes:*
 - How have people responded to that?
 - Has there been any opposition? What form did it take?
- Looking at your time in office so far, are there things you have learned to do differently – or things you now avoid – because of how people respond? *[Note: Adaptive behavior probe. Analytically important for understanding the 'chilling effect' of backlash on substantive authority.]*

Section 6 – Reflection and closing

- When things have been hard, what has kept you going? Where do you draw strength from?
- If a young SC leader in a nearby village came to you tomorrow and said they were thinking of contesting for mukhiya, what would you tell them? What would they need to know? *[Note: Projective question. Often surfaces the most condensed, reflective account of the participant's most salient experiences, because they are framing it as advice rather than autobiography.]*
- Is there anything important about your experience as mukhiya that we have not talked about today – something you would like me to understand?
- Do you have any questions for me before we finish?

[Close recording. Thank participant warmly. Collect demographic information. Remind of confidentiality. Offer support resources if sensitive material was discussed.]

Demographic information (collected after recording ends):

- Panchayat name, block, district (for researcher records only – will be pseudonymized)
- Participant's name (for researcher records only – will be pseudonymized)
- Reservation category of the seat (SC / SC-Women / unreserved)
- Approximate age
- Education level

- Number of terms served as mukhiya
- Previous political experience in family (family members as mukhiya, ward members, etc.)
- Main source of household income / occupation before becoming mukhiya
- Approximate panchayat population
- Approximate SC population percentage in panchayat
- Dominant caste groups in the panchayat